



Patterns of Religious/Spiritual Engagement Among Sexual and Gender Minorities of Color

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Disclosure



U.S. National
Science Foundation

This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship Program under Grant No. DGE 21-46756. Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation.

Overview

- ① Why does religion/spirituality matter for SGMs?
- ② Why focus on SGMs of Color?
- ③ How is R/S engagement connected to health?

Health Disparities in SGMs

SGMs are at **1.50 to 4.81 higher odds** risk of experiencing:

- internalized (e.g., depression, suicide ideation) and
- externalized (e.g., alcohol misuse) psychopathological symptoms

(Liu et al., 2024; Wittgens et al., 2022; Valen et al., 2025)

What is driving SGM health disparities?

Religiousness can contribute to SGM health disparities

Recent studies

- anti-LGBTQ+ religious exemption legislation (Todd et al., 2024)
- Religiously-based family expectations (Kim et al., 2024)
- Internal conflict (Gibbs & Goldbach, 2015)

Religion is deeply connected to SGMs

>**78% of all SGMs are raised religions** (Lefevor et al., 2023)

48% of all SGMs identify as religious (Public Religion Research Institute, 2024) and highly value religion (Conron et al., 2020).

Key Point

R/S matters to SGMs and their health.

So is Religiousness = Bad?

Not quite.



THIS ARTICLE HAS BEEN CORRECTED. SEE LAST PAGE

Psychological Bulletin

In the public domain
ISSN: 0033-2909

2021, Vol. 147, No. 7, 647–666
<https://doi.org/10.1037/bul0000321>

The Relationship Between Religiousness and Health Among Sexual Minorities: A Meta-Analysis

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Recap

- 1 SGMs have high health disparities
- 2 Religiousness contributes to health disparities
- 3 R/S and health relationship is complicated
- 4 R/S is important to SGMs

Key Question

How do SGMs engage with R/S?

Existing studies

Prior studies focus on:

- 1 Mostly White SGMs
- 2 LDS or Christian only samples

Key Gap

Even though **SGMs of Color** are more religious than White SGMs.

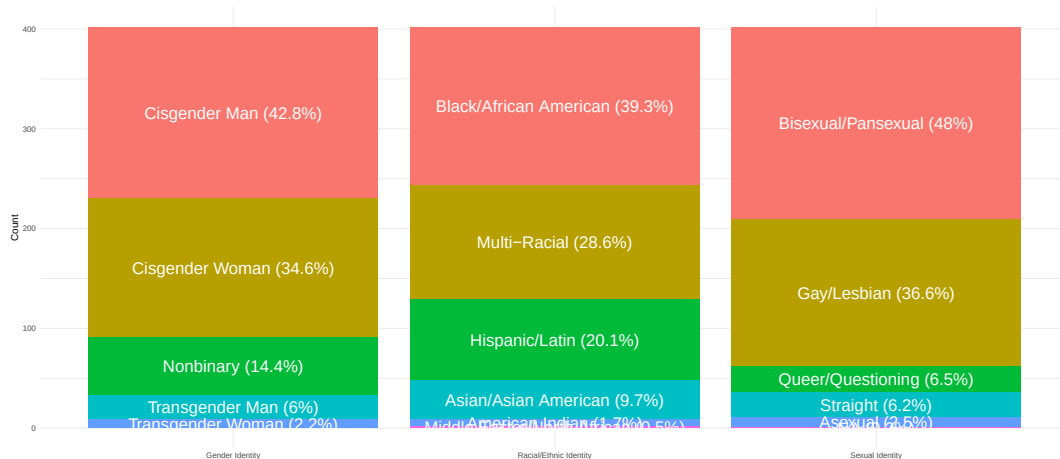
Research Question

- ① How do SGMs of Color engage with R/S?
- ② Who is more likely to engage with R/S?
- ③ How is this connected to health and other outcomes?

Data and Open Materials

- Meets **Gold** Standard of Reproducibility (Heil et al., 2022)
- Data and materials are available on Github.
- Data is provided by the **Tyler Lefevor** and the **Public Religion Research Institute**.
- 401 of 1,253 LGBTQ+ Americans identified as BIPOC in 2023.

Participants and Procedure (N=401)



Measures Pt. 1

Behavioral Measures of R/S

- Service Attendance (i.e., not including funerals)
- Spiritual Activity (i.e., prayer, scripture, meditation)

Psychological Measure of Religiousness

- Religious Commitment (i.e., intrinsic religious commitment)

Social Measure of Religiousness

- Sense of Belonging with Religious Community

Measures Pt. 2

Mental Health

- PHQ-9

LGBTQ+ Measures

- Internalized Homonegativity
- LGBTQ+ Community Connectedness

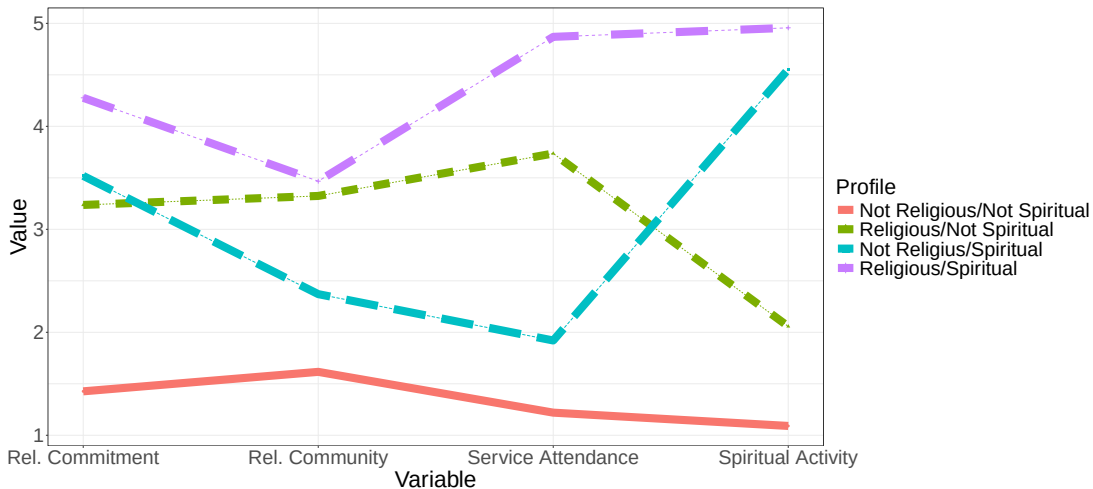
Religious Outcome Measures

- Religious and Sexual/Gender Internal Conflict
- Interpersonal Religious Struggles (i.e., felt hurt by R/S people)

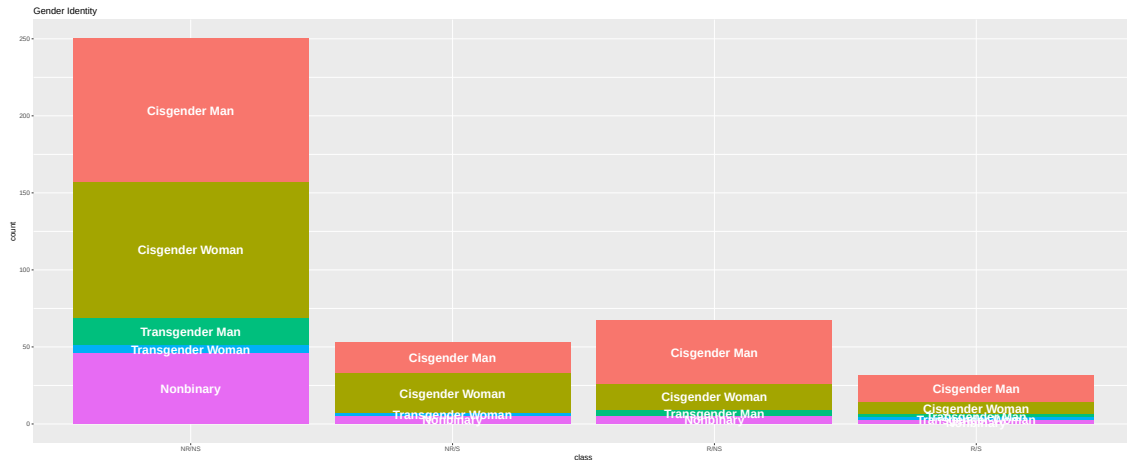
Analysis Plan

- Latent profile analysis tidySEM package
- Multinomial logistic regression using profile probabilities
- BCH distal outcome

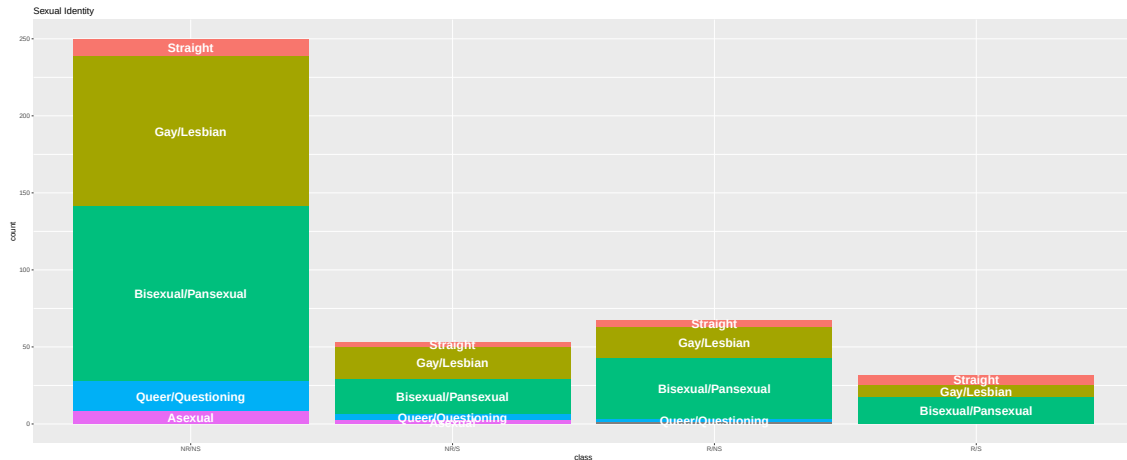
Latent Profile Analysis



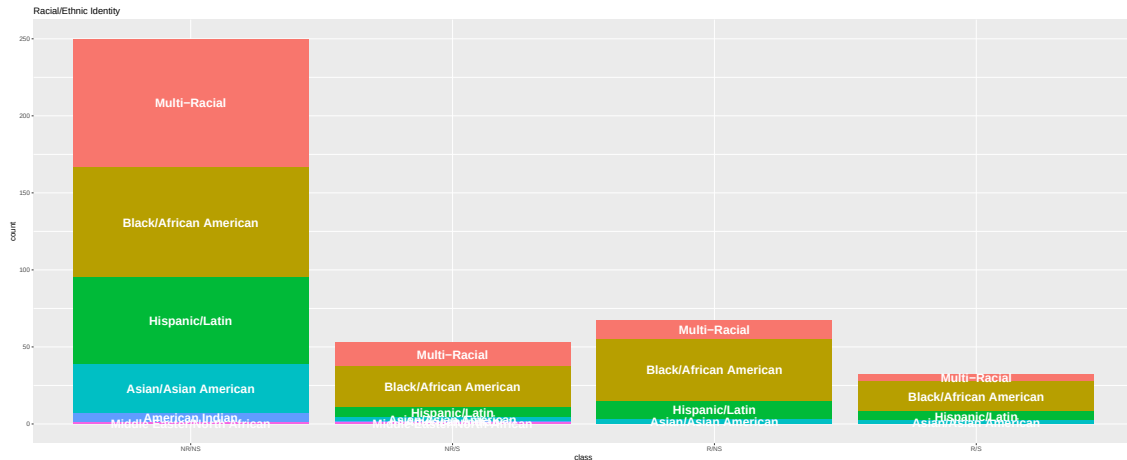
Demographic Predictors: Gender Identity



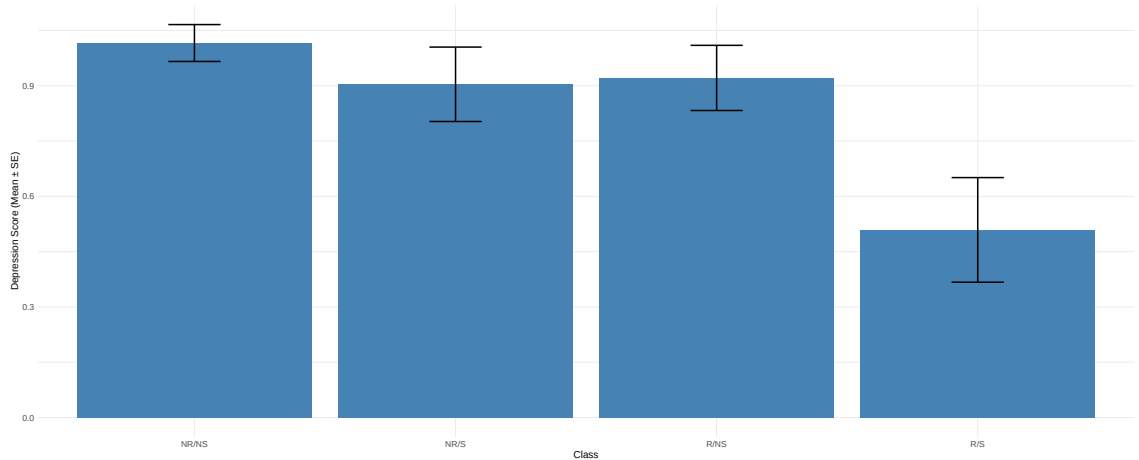
Demographic Predictors: Sexual Identity



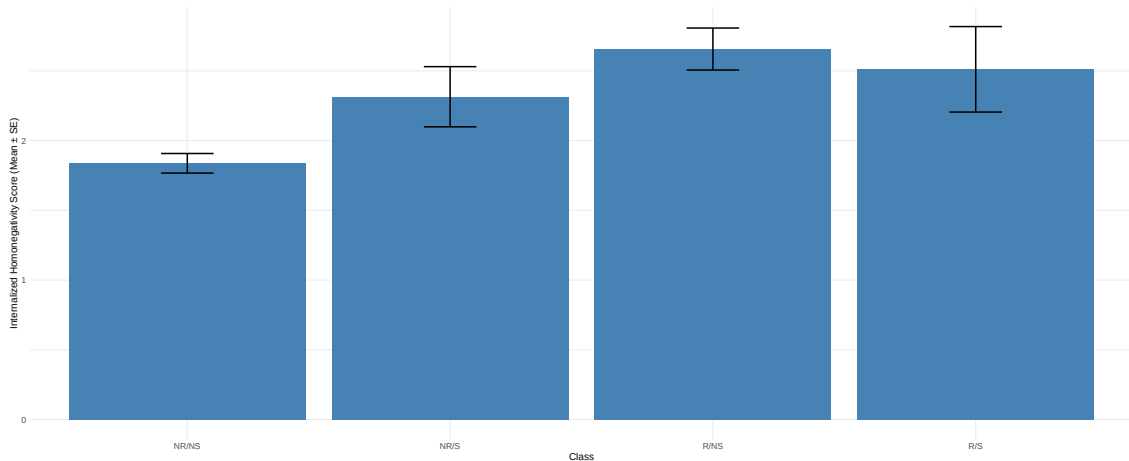
Demographic Predictors: Racial/Ethnic Identity



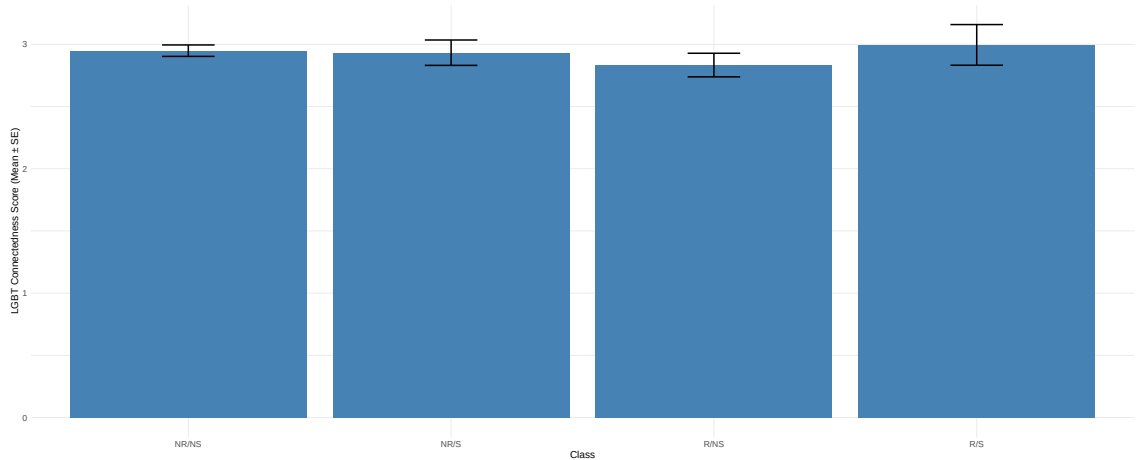
Outcome: Depression



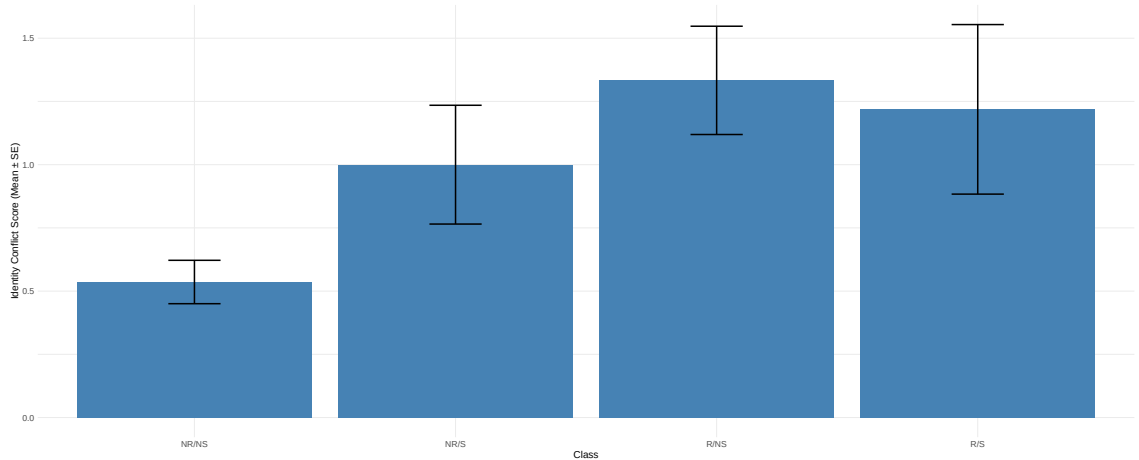
Outcome: Internalized Homonegativity



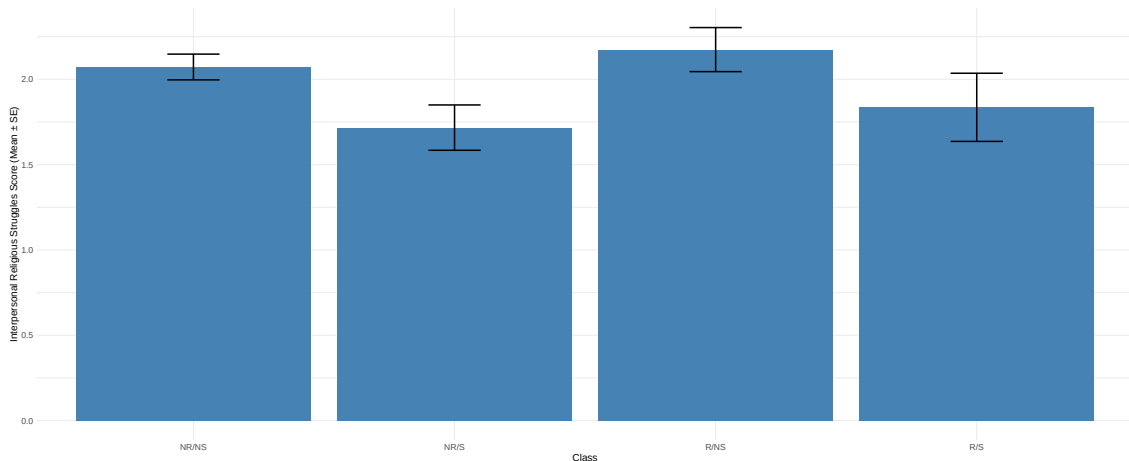
Outcome: LGBT Community Connectedness



Outcome: RS/SGL Conflict



Outcome: Interpersonal Religious Struggles



R/S matter to SGMs

- Although most SGMs were NR/NS, a substantial minority are in some form.
- Regardless of R/S engagement, all report high levels of connectedness to LGBT Community

Key point

This reflects the broader literature, 48% of SGMs are religious, and also highly value religion.
Religion matters to SGMs.

R/S engagement is linked to health and identity development

- R/S SGMs reported the lowest levels of depression
- NR/NS reported lowest levels of internalized stigma
- NR/NS reported lowest levels of internal conflict

Key points

- 1 R/S can promote health AND
- 2 R/S can promote stressors

Future directions

- ➊ Using psychometrically validated measures of religiousness and spirituality.
- ➋ What are the mediators driving these associations?
- ➌ Why do some racial/ethnic SGMs report higher R/S engagement than others?